GDP grew at an average rate of 3 per cent per annum. With its entry into the WTO in 2001, China had relatively free access to the major consumer markets of the US, Western Europe and Japan. It also received substantial inflows of capital. India, too, benefited from a more open global economy after it adopted its economic reforms programme in the early 1990s. It was able to achieve a GDP growth rate of 8–9 per cent per annum during the years 2003–2007. The global financial and economic crisis in 2008 significantly altered the global economic environment, with market access being restricted through adoption of protectionist measures. The growth in world trade fell below GDP growth and has remained mostly stagnant since. The external economic environment has become more challenging for a country like India to pursue an investment- and export-driven growth strategy.

China has pursued a development trajectory which is resource intensive and highly energy intensive. Its demand for raw materials for its industries and energy resources like coal, oil and gas have become a large proportion of the global demand. But no large emerging economy such as India can replicate China's pattern of growth. There is no place for another China in the global economy because there are simply not enough resources in the world to meet the scale of demand this would entail. Therefore, rather than follow in China's footsteps and soon reach a dead end, India needs to design and implement its own resource-frugal and sustainable-energy-oriented growth strategy. It can still do this because it is not fully locked into the kind of economic structure characteristic of China. This would also help meet the challenge of climate change and ecological degradation which are the inevitable result of the traditional growth strategies associated with industrialized economies based on the use of fossil fuels. The world is already moving away from fossil fuels, and it is better for India to stay ahead of the curve by shifting to renewable and cleaner sources of energy even faster than it is already doing.

There is much that India should learn from China. For example, China's economic success is integrally linked to the single-minded promotion of its human resources through quality education at all levels. It has invested